



b. 1960 · Lebanese-American essayist, statistician and former trader.

"It is the rare event that ruins you."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Taleb is concerned with the rare, high-impact event that conventional models ignore — and with building systems that survive, even benefit from, such shocks.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on trading, probability and philosophy, he attacked naïve reliance on the normal distribution and on prediction, arguing that fragility to tail events is the central risk.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Black Swan Radar in Unit 3's risk-and-trade-off Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His thinking operationalises as a preference for robustness and optionality over precise forecasting, and as relentless attention to downside tail risk.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Critics find his arguments combative and sometimes unfalsifiable, and note that 'avoid fragility' is easier to state than to implement.

ENDURING IMPACT

The Black Swan reshaped popular and professional thinking about risk after the 2008 crisis, and 'black swan' entered everyday language.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Cathy O'Neil · Giant 12

Andrew Ng · Giant 13

Roy Schwartz et al. · Giant 14

J.B. Quinn · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Taleb, N.N. (2007) The Black Swan. London: Penguin.

Taleb, N.N. (2012) Antifragile. New York: Random House.